

NHS A&E Performance Analysis — Key Findings

This analysis uses NHS England monthly A&E attendance data from 2019 to 2026 to examine performance trends, seasonal patterns, and trust-level variation in England

Key Findings

- 12-hour wait breaches increased significantly between 2019 and 2023, indicating growing pressure on emergency departments beyond the headline performance figure.
- Seasonal analysis shows performance is consistently lowest in December and highest in April, confirming that winter pressures remain a structural challenge across all regions.
- At trust level, performance varies significantly — the highest performing trust averaged 100% against the lowest at 39.6%, a gap of 60.4 percentage points.
- 4-hour A&E performance declined from approximately 85.13% in 2019 to 75.69% in 2023, representing a fall of 9.44 percentage points over four years.

Recommendations

- Targeted winter surge capacity planning is needed in NHS England East of England and NHS England South West, which consistently fall below the national average during November to March.
- Trusts with sustained performance below 75% should be prioritised for operational support, particularly those showing a worsening year-on-year trend.
- The significant rise in 12-hour breaches warrants separate monitoring as a standalone metric alongside the 4-hour target.

Data Source:

Data sourced from *NHS England A&E Attendances and Emergency Admissions monthly statistics*. Available at england.nhs.uk